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WP1 - The role of inaccuracies in Haikyuu

With television and media being such a big part of so many people's daily lives, everybody has their opinion. Some people enjoy science films, but don't want the movie to be "too sciency". Others enjoy history movies, but don't enjoy documentaries because they are too boring for the audience. It seems like the one thing everybody can agree on is that nobody likes watching a bad movie. However, nobody can agree on what exactly makes a movie "bad". Maybe the movie is bad because it is too long. Maybe it's bad because it's not funny enough. Or maybe the movie is perceived poorly because it took too many creative liberties and created a completely unrealistic world that just doesn't make sense to the audience anymore. This argument over accuracy and inaccuracy in movies and television shows is a tightrope that movie directors walk every day. Directors want to make the best, most entertaining, and most engaging movie that is possible. To accomplish this, directors use accuracies and inaccuracies as tools to appeal to audiences oftentimes striking a balance between the two.

When it comes to the balance between accuracy and inaccuracy in film and media, the most popular train of thought when it comes to accuracy and inaccuracy within popular television and media is that accuracy creates engagement with audiences and inaccuracy is used for entertainment purposes. The logic behind the pro-accuracy argument is that when the piece of media is accurate to the real world, it is more relatable to the audience since they already largely understand the setting of the film. Furthermore, it creates a sense of interest in the audience that undoubtedly draws audiences in. An example of this would be in Steven Spielberg's *Saving Private Ryan* which is hailed for its accuracy, is one of the most popular movies of all time

largely thanks to its meticulous attention to detail. The logic behind the pro-inaccuracy argument is that it is okay for pieces of media to have inaccuracies because they often make the movie more entertaining. An example of this would be the *Star Wars* series. The *Star Wars* series is not meant to be portrayed or interpreted as accurate to the real world. However, as one of the most popular series ever, it is obvious that the fantasy and unrealistic aspect of the series plays a huge role in its popularity, strengthening the argument that inaccuracies are used for entertainment in popular media. However, there are many pieces of media that do not fit the mold that this argument has created.

One of these non-conformist pieces of media is the sports anime, *Haikyuu*. This series follows Shoyo Hinata, a high school student who dreams of becoming a great volleyball player. In his journey to become a legendary player, Hinata joins his high school's volleyball team where he creates bonds with friends who also serve as mentors to him and his game. With the help of his coaches and team, he learns the game of volleyball at a fast pace and constantly improves by facing and overcoming a number of challenges. Throughout the series, we see some of the school's intense and important matches that decide the fate of the team and their ability to continue playing. Oftentimes during games, some of the players will have full conversations with each other in the middle of an intense rally. This can be seen when watching Season 3 Episode 10, Battle of the Concepts, where Hinata's team competes against a rival high school in a qualifier match where the winner would advance to the national level tournament. In the match, Kageyama, the setter for the team, tells Hinata, "Run the minus tempo now Hinata!" while he is preparing to set the ball. Later in the episode, Hinata gets hit in the face by a ball that is traveling extremely fast, but still manages to successfully hit the ball up and give his team a chance to play

it. While the ball is still in play, one of Hinata's teammates disregards the play and comes over to Hinata to check on him asking him if he's okay and helping Hinata up.

As someone who has played volleyball for eight years, it can confidently be said that players having full conversations with each other while the ball is in the air is completely inaccurate. Volleyball is a naturally fast paced and unforgiving sport. Points are often won and lost in no more than just a few short seconds with rallies being characterized by speed, power, and quick reactions. If players lose focus for even a fraction of a second, the other team will take notice and take advantage of this fault in focus by targeting him or her to score an easier point. With a typical volleyball rally lasting just around five seconds, any lack of complete focus will lead to the ball coming back at the "weak link" right away. This being said, it is worth noting that communication is a crucial part of the game. However, it is executed in a completely different way than is seen in the show. All teams have callouts that players will use to communicate while on the court. Some of these callouts include "Four!", "Mine!", and "Two on!". These callouts are never more than a few words, and help players understand either where their teammates plan to put the ball or the blocking structure that the opposing team is using. Another way players communicate is through the use of hand signals, before the ball is served. Both of these will help teams be on the same page and communicate what the best play is and how players should position themselves. Therefore, it is completely inaccurate for players in the show to be having full conversations, or even full sentences, while the ball is being played as it would distract players from the play and take away from their ability to be effective on the court, resulting in losing points for their team.

Despite players in the anime talking mid rally being a clear inaccuracy to how volleyball is played, it does not follow the cookie cutter mold created by the standard argument previously

explained. While the standard argument states that inaccuracies play a role of providing entertainment, the inaccuracies seen in *Haikyuu* play a different role. Instead, these inaccuracies provide accessibility, allowing people who are unfamiliar with the sport of volleyball and how it is played to follow and understand what is going on in the game. Without these mid rally conversations, it would be impossible for the audience to understand why players are making certain decisions. For example, if Hinata were to run a minus tempo four attack and hit a straight ball, while viewers would be able to see what happened, they would not be able to understand why a straight ball is better compared to a cross ball in that scenario. Furthermore, viewers may be confused as to why a minus tempo attack is superior to a second tempo attack in that scenario. This would confuse many viewers and rather than being engaged from the accuracy of the anime, which is what the standard argument argues, they would become confused as to what is going on in the play. This confusion would in turn deter them from watching the show because they are unfamiliar with the game and are not understanding the context and thought that goes into each play.

Some may critique that the argument that *Haikyuu*'s inaccuracies play an accessibility role is just a different way of saying that the inaccuracies create entertainment. However, this argument is flawed. The idea that the conversations serve as a way for non-volleyball experts to understand the game and overall series is very different from the idea that the conversations in the series create entertainment for the audience. If comparing the two, the best way to see their relationship is that the conversations act as the doorway to entertainment, not the entertainment itself. Once the metaphorical door that stops non-volleyball players from understanding the game is opened by the conversations, the audience can then fully understand the drama and buildup that the anime is known and appreciated for, which is the true entertainment in the show.

Understanding the inaccuracies and entertainment in this way, it can be said that Haikyuu's inaccuracies play an accessibility role rather than the entertainment role that the standard argument would normally predict.

While it is true that many shows and movies follow the mold of the standard argument, stating that accuracy is engaging and inaccuracies are entertaining, this does not tell the whole story. There are a myriad of shows that use accuracies and inaccuracies in other ways as well that also deserve analysis and attention. Furthermore, Haikyuu can be seen as a perfect example of how using inaccuracies or exaggerations of the accurate truth can be extremely helpful in both storytelling from the perspective of a director, and also from the perspective of the audience in understanding the story. Admittedly, when I watched Haikyuu for the first time, I was frustrated at the inaccuracies. When talking about the anime, I would tell people that I did not really enjoy it because the portrayal of volleyball plays, decisions in games, and the natural flow of games were inaccurate. However, after rewatching Haikyuu, I realized that the inaccuracies were not part of the series due to the creators' lack of knowledge, but instead as a way to explain the show to others. I learned that rather than criticizing a director's decision to use accuracy or inaccuracy in a certain situation, I should ask why it is that the director made that decision. Next time you see a movie or show, put yourself in the shoes of the director and ask yourself if you would have made the same decision as the directors if trying to tell the same story that they are telling.